

When authorities are unsafe to approach

PREPAREDNESS / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

If contacting an official could expose you or your family to harm, prioritise immediate physical safety and use trusted private contacts or independently verified humanitarian and local legal support when safe. Do not publish sensitive locations or confront armed personnel. Keep essential documents and a realistic shelter or relocation plan.

Do now.

- ☐ **Assess the actual threat**
01 Separate verified incidents and direct threats from rumours. Think about who can access your location or information and whether a call, visit or public post could increase exposure.
- ☐ **Identify independent support**
02 Find humanitarian or local legal contacts through their own websites or a trusted existing relationship. Verify a contact through a second channel before sharing sensitive details.
- ☐ **Limit unnecessary exposure**
03 Share your location and travel plans only with people who need them. Review location sharing and account access; do not assume an app or a private message guarantees confidentiality.
- ☐ **Prepare essential records**
04 Keep identification, medicines, written contacts and copies of necessary documents accessible. Store backups securely without exposing other family members.
- ☐ **Choose a practical safety plan**
05 Agree where the household can shelter, who can host you and how to reconnect if separated. Avoid confrontational actions that increase immediate danger.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

If no safe support channel is available, keep the family together in the safest reachable place and reduce unnecessary travel and disclosure. Reassess opportunities using verified information rather than a promised rescue.

Watch for.

This page cannot guarantee privacy, legal protection or safe passage. Do not record, photograph or document an incident if doing so increases immediate danger.

People & practical needs.

Assign a trusted adult to each person who needs assistance. Keep medicines, essential contacts and a workable reunion plan with the group

Next decision.

Qualified local advice matters because legal protections, detention risks and available services differ. Independent support may also be unavailable; build the plan around the resources you actually have.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

SOURCES / SCOPE / LIMITS

Source-linked civilian guidance, not independent clinical or specialist certification. U.S. references; emergency numbers and services differ. Training and product instructions remain essential.

[Access Now](#) · [Digital Security Helpline](#)

[UNHCR](#) · [Help](#)

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/preparedness/unsafe-authorities/>